infrastructure as well as the application. However, investing in these resources and infrastructure can be a challenge for an SME that may not have the required capital or number of employees. Small businesses have the advantage of being able to situate themselves better due to organisational efficiency, process familiarity, and less chances for error. In the case of automating an SME, a cloud implementation comes to the rescue."

Contrary to popular belief that RPAs are only for large organisations, the RPA market is evolving to become more affordable for SMBs and SMEs who are focusing on it to stay ahead of their competitors. According to a report from Grand View Research, the large enterprise segment accounted for more than 67 per cent share of the global RPA revenue in 2019, while BFSI led the market in terms of application with more than 29 per cent share of the global revenue. But over the forecast period from 2020-2027, SMEs are projected to witness the highest CAGR, with the pharma and healthcare sector on the forefront application-wise.

Sirisha says, "In India, most, if not all, automakers are using RPA in some form or the other. The influence of RPA would increase even more in the near future. Thus, RPA can be a vital tool for SMEs to increase productivity and save time. However, we need to consider the budgetary constraints here a little bit as the transformation to RPA can be very capital and effort-intensive in the first few steps. SMEs need to evaluate where they have a majority of redundant tasks and start from there. Steadily they can add more tools as they move ahead."

However, there may not be a great demand for automation in very small companies that just started. By filtering the most inefficient processes, you can quickly identify how to best automate.

The strategy

Okay, you think you should invest. What next? Ensure that RPA can address the gaps in the current system adequately and bring benefits to the organisation as a whole. The decision-makers can work with the employees to understand how a process works and the benefits RPA can bring.

Generally, time-consuming business processes that have well-defined rule-based steps and involve large volumes of data are suitable candidates for RPA implementation.

After finalising the processes that need to be automated, assessing ROI for individual processes is essential to quantify the benefits. The pace of change may vary from a few weeks to some months according to the business needs and scope of automation.

Finally, choose appropriate RPA toolsets and test them before implementing them into a real working environment. The bots can be run in manual mode initially so that errors can be noted. First, get started with the basics, and then gradually increase RPA deployment. Sirisha says, "Compatibility for integration with existing machinery and systems need to be verified before the investment plan for RPA. The other aspect to consider before RPA planning would be the constraint of standardisation for horizontal deployment across multiple locations of the same organisation."

Here is a video that talks about how companies begin with RPA deployment: *https://www.automationanywhere.com/company/blog/learn-rpa/three-bot-types-of-an-rpa-practice-that-scales*

Pros

The numerous advantages of RPA are the reasons you would want to go for it.

- Unlike humans, RPA can constantly work 24/7 and never make mistakes. It relieves the employees from non-value-adding tasks, increasing the speed and productivity of work. Moreover, even a non-technical person can be trained to automate RPA tools.
- Bots are reliable when it comes to complying with existing regulations and standards, and their operation is continuously monitored.
- Unlike traditional automation, RPA uses software bots that can be easily programmed to understand user actions.
- It requires little integration, that is, it can be installed on a desktop or cloud environment, making it suitable for remote working. It is scalable as multiple operations can run simultaneously, and additional bots can be added depending on the workload.
- Finally, companies deploying RPA can witness a positive ROI within a year or two.

Cons

When talking about SMBs and SMEs, there might be a tradeoff between the feature and budget.

Although there are tons of vendors in the market, the tool that fits your budget might not necessarily mean that it has all the features that you need for successful automation. This is especially true at a time like this where it is difficult to raise funding. In such a case, deploying the tool would rather cause new problems than solving the existing ones.

The time taken for complete implementation can be quite different in theory and practice based on the process choices made. Additionally, their maintenance requires extra expenditure as well as time, which can be a daunting process.

The majority of the solutions available in the market have limitations when it comes to adapting to a changing business process, making it difficult to find a scalable and customised solution for your business.

While AI integration is gradually increasing, most of the tools cannot still take on advanced cognitive tasks that need learning from unstructured elements. Such tasks often lead to a complex RPA approach that is difficult to define and implement.

How to assess ROI

Assessing ROI depends on whether you want to calculate the ROI for a single process or a complete programme. Then build a business case for your project, which compares benefits against the costs incurred in the upcoming weeks or months. Quantitatively speaking, the most basic formula for ROI would be the difference between the cost of automation and the cost of labour, taking into account the number of hours spent in manual work.

First, let us talk about savings.

The major benefits are the time saved and the elimination of errors. The time taken by employees to manually work on processes such as data